much later after the successful completion of the operation. On reaching Pune, Hasab would first call me, wanting to know the result of the operation—how many terrorists were killed? Two? Or three? When this happened more than once, we started considering him to be our lucky charm. If there were to be a lull in operations, Narendra, my 2iC, would request me to call Col Hasabnis over for lunch to break the dry spell.

Elections for the Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly were held in September–October 2002. The elections were in four phases, with the first phase on 16 September 2002 covering constituencies in the Battalion AOR. Polling booths were set up all over and classified as sensitive or hyper-sensitive, depending upon the local dynamics and perceived threats. This classification also helped us to focus our area domination efforts. The mandate given to us was very clear, namely, that we were to provide prophylactic security in our respective AOR, but we were not to go anywhere near any polling booth or carry out any activity that might be misconstrued as trying to sway or intimidate the voters. The day went by peacefully, without any untoward incident. I had been moving around throughout the day to the various Company locations, overseeing the security arrangements. By the evening, I had reached Magam and stayed there till the official polling time was over. The polling staff still had to wind up their things and that took another hour or so before they were ready to move back along with their EVMs, which incidentally had been used in J & K for the first time. Only then could we start closing in the ADPs, which were providing the prophylactic security. The ROPs would have to wait even longer, till the last of the vehicles had returned safely before they could be reeled-in. Having seen off the polling staff and their vehicles, I too started back in my Gypsy with my QRT comprising escorts front and back. As we were crossing

Copyright © Penguin Random House India Not for circulation